attacks, but whether this included targeting guidance or simply instructions to ‘do something big’ is unclear. Among the Indian security establishment, there was confusion regarding both who ordered the attacks and the nature of their objectives. Indian militants were undoubtedly involved in executing the operation, but at the time there were some in New Delhi who believed members of the ISI in Pakistan who wanted to scupper the peace process had pulled the strings.[40]

Whether or not ISI officers were actively seeking to spoil the peace process, the agents tasked with handling those Lashkar operatives who coordinated operations against India would have known about the attacks. These line officers enjoyed significant operational latitude, in part to provide their leaders with plausible deniability, and often acted upon their own initiative when it came to managing relations with the militants they handled. This remained the case at the time of writing. As one observer has noted, ISI operations were (and still are) typically regulated by ‘directive control’ rather than ‘detailed control’ meaning field officers were empowered to act without prior approval from their superiors.[41] The Musharraf regime’s decision to maintain Lashkar as an asset with which to apply calibrated pressure also meant directives from Islamabad were relative rather than absolute. In other words, they were open to interpretation. Out of loyalty to Lashkar, ideological inclinations or their own sense of what served Pakistan’s interests, some field officers took advantage of the ambivalent nature of Musharraf’s policies. Thus, even if the attacks were not sanctioned at the highest levels, this does not absolve the Musharraf regime of responsibility. Regardless of who ordered the attacks, one thing was certain: talk about peace could not continue.

New Delhi publicly terminated the public dialogue with Pakistan that had been moving steadily forward since 2004. Under international pressure, Hafiz Saeed was placed under house arrest on 10 August.[42] He was released on 29 August after the Lahore High Court ruled that the government had failed to provide evidence for his detention, but detained once again only hours later for a two-month period.[43] This appears to have been done in anticipation of a meeting between Musharraf and Singh on the sidelines of the Non-Aligned Movement summit in September. Dialogue between the two leaders during that summit helped to forge an agreement the following March [2007] to establish the Anti-Terrorism Mechanism to